

The Driving Force behind Voice Recognition in Office XP

It's extremely difficult for a developer to build a speech engine that can understand virtually every word spoken. However, over a period of time software developers have been able to ensure an accuracy level that is above 95 per cent. Office XP's ability to understand and use spoken language is based on a Microsoft technology called the Speech Application

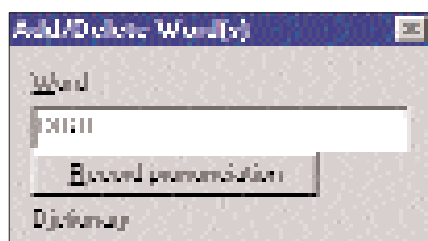
Programming Interface (SAPI) that's also being used by a growing array of independent software developers to speech-enable their own applications. Microsoft has been researching and promoting speech-enabled software since the mid-1990s, and its SAPI is the most popular PC-based speech-to-text and speech recognition interface in the industry.



The Minimum Requirements

for using the speech feature of Office XP are a Pentium II 400 MHz processor with 128 MB of RAM. You also need a high-quality close talk microphone, preferably a USB microphone with gain adjustment. SoundBlaster Live! is an ideal soundcard since it puts very little processing overhead on the CPU.

You can manually make corrections using the keyboard/mouse or by clicking on the 'Correction' button on the Speech toolbar even while you are dic-



Manually add/delete words

tating. The voice recognition feature can be used in other programs such as Excel, Outlook, PowerPoint or FrontPage wherein you can dictate numbers and even formulae into a spreadsheet or dictate the contents of a PowerPoint presentation.

Voice commands: You can open files or use any menu driven commands, by activating 'Voice Command' on the Speech toolbar. By simply mentioning the name of the menu, the menu list will open and all you have to do is speak out the specific command you want to use. For exam-

ple, if you want to create a new file you will have to say "File" and the file menu will drop down. Now say "New" and a new file will open.

That's it. You can now go ahead and talk to your computer. Remember, you would need to invest a lot of time in training the software to recognise your voice. Your initial experience might be frustrating, but patience is all you require. Soon all you'll need is a microphone, with the keyboard and mouse finding their way into the Recycle Bin.

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